

Weekly Reading Reflections #9: Sergio Monterroso

Mt. Hope Cemetery Discussion

Ancestry Discussion

In class, we used Ancestry.com to conduct some genealogy work by looking at a compilation of multiple archives to find our family roots. In the past, I've done similar work with my family to see what I could find. Unfortunately, I returned empty-handed and today was just as expected. I was only able to find information on my father and his past lived residences — information that I already knew. My family's history was not accessible because of how it came to the United States in just the generation before mine. My father came to the United States in the 90s as a refugee of a civil war in Guatemala, and my mother also came from around the same time. The amount of government records they can produce so far are little to catch the attention of websites like Ancestry.com, but the fact that they are so early into their journey in the United States provoked some interesting thoughts on this exercise.

Why can I find my father but not my mother? Though my experience is just anecdotal, it struck me that our system makes it easier to establish a male name as opposed to a female name. Men make more money, has more money, and can afford to get a mortgage on a house like my father did — but my mother can't because she doesn't make as much. She has less encounters with "the system" to establish her name and identity, so it will take longer for her to eventually show up on databases like Ancestry.com. This line of thinking led me to connect our discussion to past units: Ancestry.com is an archive and the archives are never apolitical or unbiased, and sometimes the absence of something speaks louder than the presence of something else. Here, the absence of my mother's record screamed politics.

Cemetery Discussion

Early into the discussion with Dr. Johnson, she asked the class a simple question: "why do we keep cemeteries?" My review of the previous day's work told me to look at everything as an archive, so I answered in class: "why do we keep archives? They're records of the past, just like cemeteries — cemeteries are archives." This was apparently hitting the nail on the head for the rest of discussion, and I didn't even know it at the time. We began discussing graves of all varieties: state graves for military members, unmarked graves, mass graves, and forgotten graves. This furthered my line of thinking from Monday. Like how genealogical databases are archives of the dead, cemeteries are also archives of the deceased.

The discussion later evolved into how we can see evidence of uncared cemeteries and what that typically means. Slave cemeteries are usually not registered with the state records nor cared for. Sometimes they feature unmarked gravestones or simply no gravestones whatsoever. Another factor that can politicize these archives is the handling of them with respect to laws like NAGPRA, which was made to protect Native American graves from pillaging but also functions to obstruct repatriation and identification of remains. KJ brought up a great point about how slave gravesites aren't treated the same as Native American ones with respect to legal instruments like NAGPRA, which was

interesting to me that the question of whether a grave can be legally disturbed remains to the cohesion of the group: you can't repatriate Black remains to just Black Americans, there has to be defined group like Native American tribes. The politics behind these decisions throws a tantrum in the face of historians and their research even in simple public histories like genealogical research.